

THE CIRCUS STORIES / FOR / 7 FINGERS

INTERVIEW PROPOSAL FOR LOUIS BOURGAUT

Head of Casting at The 7 Fingers

From — Alicia & Deelia (Founders, The Circus Stories · Performers, Duo Illumi)

The Circus Stories is about the practical knowledge and stories of working in circus — casting, contracts, mental health, and how to make a life of this. Collected through interviews, the What Does Circus Pay survey, and a career course by Alicia and Deelia of Duo Illumi.

WHAT WE'RE HOPING FOR

A 30-min to 1-hour recorded interview with Louis. Fifteen questions sent in advance, with as many covered on the day as time allows. We edit, we send 7 Fingers every clip and quote for sign-off, nothing publishes without written approval. Content goes to Instagram, YouTube and the project website (launching summer 2026), our newsletter, and a career course for performers (later this year). Recording in May or June, publication from July.

More on format, timeline, and approval below the questions.

THE 15 QUESTIONS

Most performers we know would love a real answer to at least one of these. They're the questions that keep coming up backstage.

Approve, edit, or remove each question as you go. If something else is blocking a yes to the interview, tell us. We'd love to find a way.

01 Tell us about a moment watching someone where you knew, before the act was over, that you wanted them in a 7 Fingers show. What were they doing?

02 Talking about bios and act descriptions. When a performer writes about their act or what they're trying to do as an artist — what makes you want to know more about them, and what reads as filler? What do you want to learn from those few sentences, or what makes you care?

03 How busy are you in a typical week? How many applications, videos, messages come through? And honestly — does it ever happen that you overlook someone because of the volume?

04 Walk us through what happens after someone uploads a profile to the 7 Fingers casting database. Who looks at it, when, how often, and what changes a profile from sitting there to getting pulled into a show? What's missing in most profiles, and any no-gos?

05 Someone's about to do their first 7 Fingers audition. Walk us through the day — what's the format, what are they asked to do, how long do they have, what do most people not realise they're being watched on?

06 Do you follow performers' progress — their training, what they're posting, where they're working? What makes you start, and what makes you stay invested?

- 07 Most duos aren't perfectly matched. One person has more experience, or one has the louder stage presence, or one is technically further along. From your side — how matched does a duo need to be for you to take them seriously? At what point is the gap a problem?
- 08 How can a performer get an outside eye on their work from a casting head? What does asking well look like, and what makes you give a sentence rather than ignore the message?
- 09 The Broadway production of *Water for Elephants* had a circus ensemble. Most of those performers had worked with 7 Fingers before. For a circus performer who isn't already in your world — how does someone get into the running for a 7 Fingers Broadway project?
- 10 When you say no to someone, what does it mean? A no for that show, a no for that year, a no forever? And what can change a no to a yes?
- 11 When a performer with a 7 Fingers contract gets injured, what does the company do for them while they're not working? And once they're back to performing — do they come back to 7 Fingers, and if so how does the process look?
- 12 Performers stop performing for all kinds of reasons. Inside 7 Fingers, is there room to move into other roles — casting, directing, rigging, choreography? And how does that usually start?
- 13 You were performing before this. How did you end up in casting? What's something you used to think when you were the one applying that turned out to be wrong?
- 14 What do performers do thinking it's networking with you, that on your end reads as noise?
- 15 Closing — most useful piece of advice for a first application.

MORE DETAIL

What this is

Most of how this industry works isn't taught anywhere. Especially if you didn't come up through the circus school path. Pay rates, how casting decides, what to ask before signing, how to have a sustainable career. Performers learn it the slow way: through bad contracts, late-night conversations, the friend who was three years ahead.

That's what The Circus Stories is for. We run the What Does Circus Pay survey, interview people across the industry, and are building a career course. We want to create useful resources for performers, and beyond that share the kinds of stories most people never hear about this work. By Alicia and Deelia of Duo Illumi, performers ourselves.

Who's been interviewed

RECORDED OR SCHEDULED WITH CONFIRMED DATES

Stacy Clark

Former Director of Casting, Cirque du Soleil

Ben Lerman

Founder, Acro Factory Entertainment · agent and aerial director

Bryan Donaldson

Rigger, multi-show experience

Tim Kriegler

Cirque de Demain silver medalist · Staatliche Artistenschule Berlin

Maria Konfektova

Aerial hoop · Guinness World Record holder

Saffi Watson

Contortion-handstand and aerial · ENC Montreal graduate

Emilia Dawiec

Aerial hoop and disco-ball hair suspension · ÉSAC Brussels graduate

James Kingsford-Smith

Acrobat and aerialist · NICA graduate · Sochi Paralympics

Diana Salles

Aerial silks · ÉSAC Brussels graduate · creator of DELUSIONAL

Daniel Simu

Juggler and interdisciplinary artist · NCCA London · creator of Acrobot

Julian McTaggart

Aerial straps and acro · NECCA graduate · Dragone TERHAL

In conversation — Additional casting directors, producers and artistic directors. Names available on request.

Format and length

Length	30 mins to 1 hour
Platform	Riverside / Zoom
Recording	Video and audio
Questions	Sent in advance

If at any point The 7 Fingers prefers Louis to speak in a personal capacity rather than as Head of Casting at the company, we're happy to adjust the framing.

Where the content goes

YouTube — Multiple 8–12 minute episodes per interview, plus YouTube Shorts. Channel launching summer 2026. A future possibility: longer compilation videos bundling multiple casting conversations — only with separate sign-off from each interviewee.

Instagram — Reels (30-90 seconds), carousels with pull-quotes, photo-quote posts. Published on @thecircusstories.

Course — Quoted with attribution inside Act to Income, our paid course for performers, launching end of 2026.

Newsletter — Quoted excerpts in the project's email newsletter to subscribers.

Website — Written companion piece on the project website.

Approval & publishing

Every piece of content that includes Louis or references The 7 Fingers is sent to the company for written approval before publication. Nothing goes live without explicit sign-off, per piece. Approval can be granted, revised, or revoked at any stage before publication.

Once we've edited the recording, we send 7 Fingers everything in one batch: the long-form video, every short clip, every carousel, every pull-quote graphic, the website article. The team reviews per piece. Anything not approved doesn't get used.

If something is approved and circumstances change, the company can revoke approval before publication and we won't publish it. The interview rushes are kept and shared with the company on request.

A note on reusing content. Once a clip or quote has been approved and published, we'd like to repost it later in different formats. For example, an approved YouTube clip turned into a Reel, or a quote pulled into the newsletter or course. The content stays the same, just shows up in a different place. If we'd ever want to use something in a way that changes the meaning or framing, we'd come back and ask.

What we won't do

- Publish anything from this interview before written approval from The 7 Fingers
- Use Louis's words, image or The 7 Fingers' name in any third-party advertising, sponsorship, or commercial promotion
- Frame the interview as exclusive 7 Fingers casting reveals or any framing that could damage the company's reputation
- Release outtakes, raw footage, or any material that wasn't explicitly approved
- Use AI or editing to alter what was said beyond standard length and clarity edits, which are also subject to approval
- Sell access to the interview itself or lock it behind a paywall

Note on the course. The career course will be paid, but every quote and clip used in it will also be available for free on YouTube, Instagram, and the website. Not as lead magnets or behind email signups — just published as freely available content.

Timeline

April-May 2026	Hoping for approval back from 7 Fingers in this window
May / June 2026	Recording, at any time that works for Louis
June onwards	Editing begins. We send 7 Fingers everything in one batch — long-form, clips, quotes — for review.
Review window	Whatever time 7 Fingers needs. We'd be hoping for around 2 weeks but no rush from our side.

July onwards

Publication of interview content begins, on a schedule that works for everyone.

CONTACTS

Alicia & Deelia

Founders, The Circus Stories · Performers, Duo Illumi

info@duoillumi.com · [@thecircusstories](#) · [@duo_illumi](#)